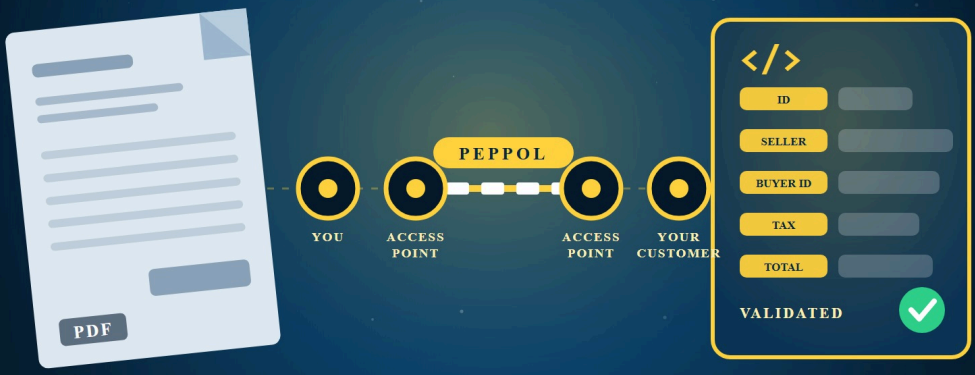
EUROPEAN E-INVOICING GUIDE

FROM PDF TO PEPPOL



- STRUCTURED DATA, NOT A PICTURE
- VALIDATED BEFORE IT IS SENT
- DELIVERED THROUGH YOUR OWN ACCESS POINT
- ARCHIVED IN ITS ORIGINAL FORM

A Small Business Guide to
Structured E-Invoicing and Europe's Digital VAT Transition

PEPPOL · CROATIA · BELGIUM · ViDA 2030

ZIRLANDIA MILKOVIC

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This book is practical guidance, not legal, tax or accounting advice. All examples, businesses and people in worked scenarios are fictional. Laws, dates and provider capabilities reflect the research cut-off date and should be checked against the current legal texts, tax-authority guidance and provider documentation.

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Educational Disclaimer

This book is practical, educational guidance for freelancers, microbusinesses, accountants, bookkeepers and small companies who are being asked to send, receive and keep invoices in a structured electronic form. It is not legal, tax or accounting advice, and it does not create a professional relationship between the author and the reader.

E-invoicing rules are national, technical and still moving. Whether you must issue a structured invoice, to whom, in which format, through which channel and by what date depends on the country where you and your customer are established, your VAT status, the type of transaction and sometimes your sector. The country sections in this book (Croatia and Belgium in detail, other countries in outline) describe the position as it could be established on the research cut-off date of 13 November 2026, mostly from secondary sources such as tax-technology providers and law-firm summaries and, for Croatia and Belgium, from pointers to the official texts that the author did not read in full. The notes at the back say what was and was not verified. Where sources disagreed, this book says so instead of choosing one.

Before you change your invoicing, register anywhere, sign a contract with a provider or promise anything to a customer, check the current rules with your tax authority, your accountant and your software provider. Following the steps here can make your move to structured invoicing calmer and easier to defend. It cannot guarantee that a tax authority will agree with every choice.

Every business, person and scenario in a worked example is **fictional** and labelled as such. Product and standard names appear only to describe how a category of tool works; no provider is recommended or criticised by this book.

Introduction: The Invoice That Was Not an Invoice

Mira is a freelance designer in Zagreb. For nine years she has made her invoices the same way: a template in a word processor, exported to PDF, attached to an email. Her clients pay. Her accountant is happy. In January, one of her larger clients, a mid-sized company registered for VAT, replied to her latest PDF with a polite note: their accounting system could not process it, and under the new national rules they could only treat an invoice as received if it arrived through an approved electronic channel in a structured format. "Could you send it again through the system?"

Mira did not know what "the system" was. She had never heard of an information intermediary. Her invoicing tool exported PDFs, full stop. She spent three evenings searching, found a dozen acronyms (UBL, CII, AS4, Peppol, EN 16931), and by the end of the week had one clear conclusion: the thing she had always called an invoice, in this client's eyes, was now only a picture of one.

Across Europe, a growing number of countries are making the same shift, at different speeds and with different rules. **The invoice is becoming data.** Instead of a document that a person reads and retypes, it is a structured file that one accounting system sends to another, that the tax authority can see or be told about, and that no human needs to key in. For large companies this has been normal for years. What is new is that the obligation is now reaching sole traders, micro-businesses and the small firms that serve them.

This book is a plain-language handbook for that transition. It does not assume you are technical. It explains what a structured e-invoice actually is, how the Peppol network carries it, how to choose software that will keep you compliant, how to archive what you send and receive, and what the real rules look like in **Croatia** (where Fiscalisation 2.0 started in 2026) and **Belgium** (where structured B2B invoicing became mandatory in January 2026). It then looks ahead to the **EU's VAT in the Digital Age (ViDA)** reform, which points to cross-border digital reporting based on e-invoicing from July 2030.

Two warnings run through every chapter. First, **European rules are not identical**. A sentence that is true in Belgium may be false in Croatia and meaningless in a country with no mandate; this book labels scope every time. Second, **you do not need to build anything**. For a small business the right answer is almost always to choose compliant software or a provider, connect it correctly, and change a few habits. You will not write XML. You will, however, need good data, a clear process and a tidy archive.

Who This Book Is For

- **Freelancers and sole traders** who issue a handful of PDF invoices a month and want to know whether, and when, that stops being enough.
- **Microbusinesses and small companies** with an invoicing tool they have never looked at closely and customers who are starting to ask awkward questions.
- **Accountants and bookkeepers** who must explain the change to dozens of small clients at once, in plain words, and often decide which software the clients will use.
- **Owners of small firms that trade across borders**, who need to understand why a Belgian customer, a Croatian supplier and a German partner may all ask for different things.
- **Office and finance managers** who have been handed "the e-invoicing project" with no budget and a deadline.

It is written from a European point of view and covers the situation of small businesses. It is not written for software vendors and it is not a tax treatise. It will tell you what to ask your accountant, in what order.

How to Use This Book

The eight chapters move from the idea to the practice to the specific countries:

1. **Why a PDF is no longer enough.** What changed, and where.
2. **Structured e-invoices explained.** What is inside, and why a PDF is not one.
3. **Peppol fundamentals.** The network that carries the invoices, without the jargon.
4. **Choosing compatible invoicing software.** What to ask and what to avoid.
5. **Digital invoice archiving.** Keeping what the law requires you to keep.
6. **Croatia's Fiscalisation 2.0.** Scope, dates, intermediaries and the free state tool.
7. **Belgium's 2026 B2B requirements.** Scope, Peppol, tolerance and penalties.
8. **Preparing for the EU VAT in the Digital Age programme.** What is coming and how to be ready.

The appendices are working documents: a readiness audit, a software-selection questionnaire, a country-scope checker, a letter to customers and suppliers, an archive register and a 90-day action plan. Copy them, fill them in and keep them current.

Look for the dark boxes headed **The rule**. Each states, in one sentence, the principle a chapter turns on. If you read nothing else, read those.

The Ten-Minute Invoice Check

Before the first chapter, answer these honestly. A "no" or "I don't know" is not a failure. It is the start of your to-do list.

- ☐ I know which countries my customers and suppliers are established in.
- ☐ I know whether I am VAT-registered, and in which country or countries.
- ☐ I can say whether any of my customers must receive invoices in a structured format.
- ☐ I know what format my current invoicing tool actually produces (PDF, image, structured file, or all of these).
- ☐ I know whether my tool can send invoices through a network or an authorised intermediary, not just by email.
- ☐ My customers' identifiers (VAT number, enterprise number, tax ID) are stored correctly in my records.
- ☐ I keep a copy of every invoice, sent and received, in a place I can find and prove unchanged.
- ☐ I know who in my business, or at my accountant, owns this topic.
- ☐ I have read what my tax authority publishes on e-invoicing for the countries where I trade.

CHAPTER 1

Why a PDF Invoice Is No Longer Enough

A desk at dusk: the paper invoice is turning into data

For thirty years the PDF has been the most convenient way to send an invoice. It looks the same everywhere, it is easy to attach, and anyone can open it. For many small businesses in many countries it is still perfectly acceptable today. The point of this chapter is to explain, calmly, **why that is changing, where, and what "not sufficient" really means.**

What counts as an electronic invoice

Under EU VAT rules, an invoice may be issued electronically if it is issued and received in any electronic format, subject to the recipient's acceptance.[13] On that definition, an emailed PDF is an "electronic invoice". That has been true for years, and it is the reason many people assume nothing has changed.

What has changed is that a growing number of national governments are adding a **second layer**: for certain transactions, the invoice only counts if it is a **structured** electronic invoice, meaning data in an agreed machine-readable format, usually exchanged through a defined channel. A PDF may still be a perfectly good *copy* for a human to read. It is no longer the invoice itself.

Why governments want this

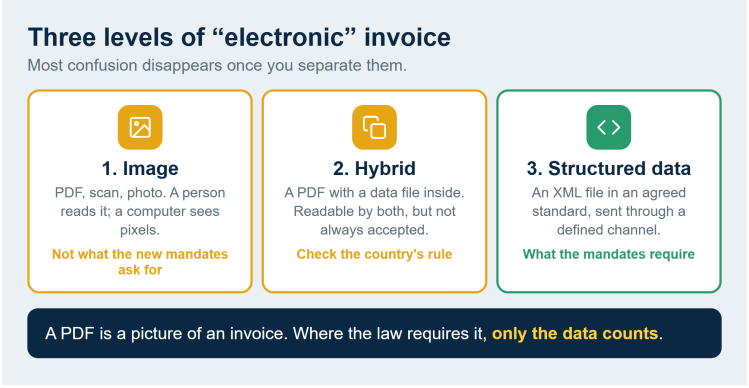
Three motives recur across the countries moving this way:

1. **Closing the VAT gap.** Tax authorities lose large sums each year to missing, false or late-reported invoices. If transactions are visible in near real time, errors and fraud are easier to spot.
2. **Cutting cost and errors.** Retyping invoice data costs businesses time and produces mistakes. Structured data can post itself into the books.
3. **Faster payment and cleaner data.** Standard fields, standard identifiers and standard tax categories make reconciliation faster and reporting simpler.

The EU frames the wider reform as modernising VAT for the digital economy.[8] Individual countries implement it with their own laws, dates and technical choices, which is why this book keeps asking you to check scope.

Three levels of "electronic"

Most confusion disappears once you separate three things that people loosely call "e-invoicing":



Three levels of electronic invoice: image, hybrid and structured data

Level 1: the image. A PDF, a scan, a photo. A human can read it; a computer sees pixels. Anyone receiving it has to type it in or run character recognition.

Level 2: the hybrid. A PDF with a structured data file embedded inside. A human sees the document; a computer can read the data. Some national formats of this kind are accepted in some countries, but they are not

what the mandates described in this book are built on. Check before you assume.

Level 3: structured data. An XML file that follows a defined standard, carried between systems through a defined channel. The "visual" invoice, if one exists, is generated from the data, not the other way round. This is the level the new mandates require.

Where the line is being drawn

Three market signals matter for the rest of this book. They are described more carefully in later chapters, with their sources and limits.

- **Croatia.** VAT-registered businesses are subject to domestic B2B e-invoicing requirements under the Fiscalisation 2.0 reforms from 2026, with the obligation to *issue* e-invoices extending to businesses outside the VAT register from January 2027.[1][2]
- **Belgium.** Structured electronic invoices became mandatory for covered domestic B2B transactions between VAT-liable businesses from January 2026. A PDF alone is not sufficient.[4][5]
- **EU level.** The ViDA reform introduces cross-border B2B digital reporting based on e-invoicing from July 2030.[8][9]

Other countries are on their own timetables, and some have no domestic mandate at all. If you trade across borders, you will meet more than one regime at once.

A map in time: when each rule in this book starts

What "not sufficient" means in practice

It rarely means a dramatic fine on the first day. It usually means one or more of the following:

- **Your customer cannot legally treat it as a valid invoice**, which can affect their VAT deduction and their willingness to pay you promptly.
- **Their system will not accept it**, so it sits in an inbox until someone chases you.
- **You are non-compliant on paper**, which exposes you to penalties that vary by country and by how willing the authority is to give time.
- **You are shut out of customers who have already switched**, including public bodies and larger companies that have a policy of only accepting structured invoices.

The rule: a PDF is a picture of an invoice. Where the law requires a structured e-invoice, only the data counts.

What does not change

Do not panic. The following stay true almost everywhere:

- You still need correct mandatory invoice content: supplier and customer details, date, number, description, VAT rate and amount.

- Your VAT obligations are unchanged. E-invoicing changes *how* the information travels, not what the tax is.
- Consumers (B2C) are generally outside these B2B mandates, though some countries have separate rules on receipts and fiscalisation (Croatia's reforms touch both, as Chapter 6 explains).
- Many small businesses, in many countries, can still send PDFs today. Your job is to know whether you are one of them, and until when.

A worked example (fictional)

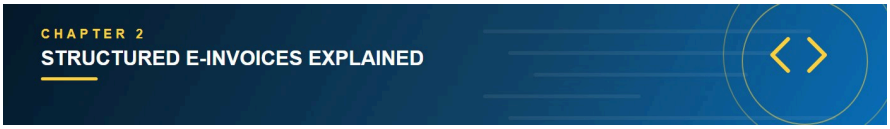
Mira, a freelance designer in Zagreb, invoices three clients. Client A is a VAT-registered Croatian company that now requires structured invoices. Client B is a Croatian sole trader outside the VAT register. Client C is a design agency in Germany. Mira's problem is not "should I e-invoice?" but "for which client, from when, and through which route?" Three clients, three answers. Chapter 6 returns to her, and Appendix C gives you a one-page way to do the same sorting for your own customers.

Take action this week

- ☐ List your ten biggest customers and ten biggest suppliers and write their country next to each.
- ☐ Ask each Belgian or Croatian customer whether they now require structured invoices, and how they want them sent.
- ☐ Ask your accountant which of your customers' countries have a mandate in force, and which are planned.
- ☐ Find out what your invoicing software exports today, and whether its provider has published an e-invoicing roadmap.

CHAPTER 2

Structured E-Invoices Explained

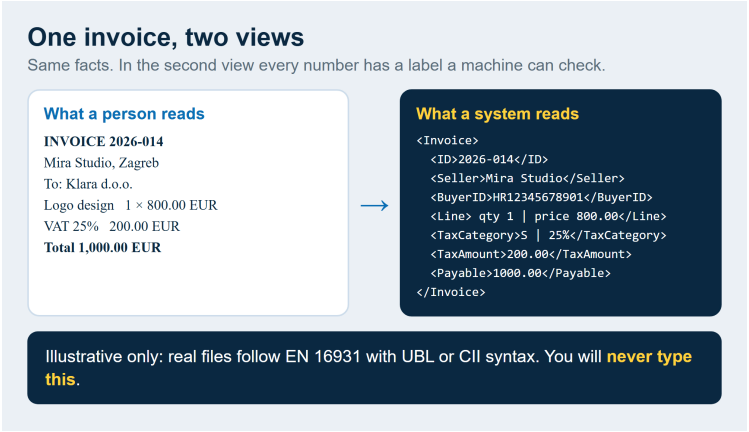


Behind every invoice is a set of fields that a machine can read

A structured e-invoice looks mysterious until you notice that it contains nothing you have not already put on every invoice you have ever sent. The difference is **how** it is written down. This chapter opens the box.

What is inside

Open any invoice and you will find the same ingredients: who is selling, who is buying, an invoice number and date, what was sold, quantities and prices, VAT rates and amounts, a total, and payment details. A structured invoice records exactly these items, but each one is a **labelled field** in a file rather than a line on a page.



One invoice, two views: what a person reads and what a system reads

In plain terms, instead of the human-readable line "Logo design, 1 x 800.00 EUR, VAT 25%", a structured invoice holds the same information as labelled data: a line, a quantity, a unit price, a tax category and a tax rate. The software on the other end does not need to guess where the VAT amount is. It is a field called "VAT amount".

Standards: the shared dictionary

For two accounting systems to understand each other, they need a shared dictionary. Europe's is a standard called **EN 16931**, the European semantic standard for the core electronic invoice, which defines what information an invoice contains and what each item means.[11] It is deliberately generic: it says what the fields are, not how they are written.

Writing them down in a file requires a **syntax**. The two syntaxes recognised for EN 16931 are usually named **UBL** and **CII**, both based on XML.[11] You will meet these acronyms in provider brochures. Think of EN 16931 as the dictionary and UBL or CII as two alphabets in which the dictionary can be written.

On top of the generic standard, countries and networks publish **profiles** (sometimes called CIUS, or "core invoice usage specifications") that narrow the choices: which fields are mandatory, which tax codes are allowed, which identifiers to use. The profile used on the Peppol network is called **Peppol BIS Billing 3.0**, and it is the one most small businesses in Europe will meet first. Croatia has national technical specifications of its own; Chapter 6 explains.

Layer	Plain meaning	Example
Semantic standard	The shared dictionary of invoice fields	EN 16931
Syntax	The file format the fields are written in	UBL or CII (XML)
Profile (CIUS)	A country or network's narrowed rules	Peppol BIS Billing 3.0; national specifications
Channel	How the file travels	A network such as Peppol; an authorised intermediary

Why a PDF is not that

A PDF can contain every field a human needs, but there is nothing in it that tells a computer which number is the VAT amount. Reading a PDF automatically means guessing: character recognition, templates, machine learning. Guessing is exactly what the new rules are designed to remove. When a government says "structured invoice", it means the data fields are explicit and validated against rules *before* the invoice is accepted.

Validation is the quiet superpower here. A structured invoice can be checked automatically: the sums must add up, the tax category must be valid for the rate, mandatory identifiers must be present, dates must make sense. An invoice that fails validation is rejected immediately with a reason, instead of lingering in a queue. This is why e-invoicing can feel stricter than PDF: it is less tolerant of the small mistakes that humans quietly fix.

The hybrid format question

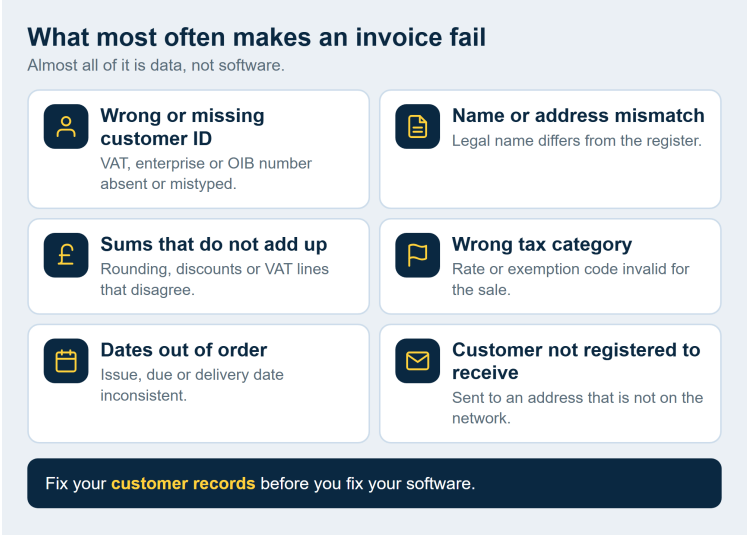
Some formats embed structured data inside a PDF so that one file serves both a human and a machine. These are useful in some markets. But a hybrid is not automatically the same thing as the structured invoice a particular mandate requires, because many mandates specify a pure data format and a specific channel. **The rule of thumb:** if a country says "structured invoice through [network or intermediary]", ask the provider explicitly whether their file is the pure format the country names, not a hybrid look-alike.

What you will actually do

You will almost never write or read the XML. A typical small-business flow looks like this:

1. You create the invoice in your invoicing or accounting software, as always.
2. The software, or a connected provider, converts it into the required structured format and validates it.
3. It is sent through the required channel to your customer's system or provider.
4. You receive a status: accepted, rejected with a reason, or delivered.
5. Your customer's system posts the invoice automatically, and you both archive the original data (Chapter 5).

Where does the risk sit? Almost always in **step 2**, and in your **data**. A structured invoice built from wrong customer data (the wrong identifier, a missing VAT number, a misspelled legal name) fails or gets rejected, however good the software is.



The data that most often makes a structured invoice fail

Credit notes and corrections

Mistakes happen, so every system needs a way to correct an invoice. In structured invoicing you generally do not edit a sent invoice; you issue a **credit note** that references the original and, if needed, a new invoice.

This is cleaner than the "version 2.pdf" habit, and it keeps the audit trail intact. Check how your software handles it before you need it.

The rule: structured invoicing rewards clean data and punishes improvisation. Fix your customer records before you fix your software.

Take action this week

- ☐ Export your customer list and check every record has the exact legal name, address, country and tax identifier.
- ☐ Ask your software provider in writing: which standard and profile do you produce, and through which channel can you send?
- ☐ Ask what happens when an invoice is rejected, and how you are told.
- ☐ Practise issuing a credit note in your current tool.

CHAPTER 3

Peppol Network Fundamentals

A network of lit connections: every business reaches every other through its own door

Peppol is the word you will hear most often, and the one most often explained badly. Strip away the acronyms and it is a simple idea: **a shared postal system for business documents, in which you only ever deal with your own post office.**

What Peppol is

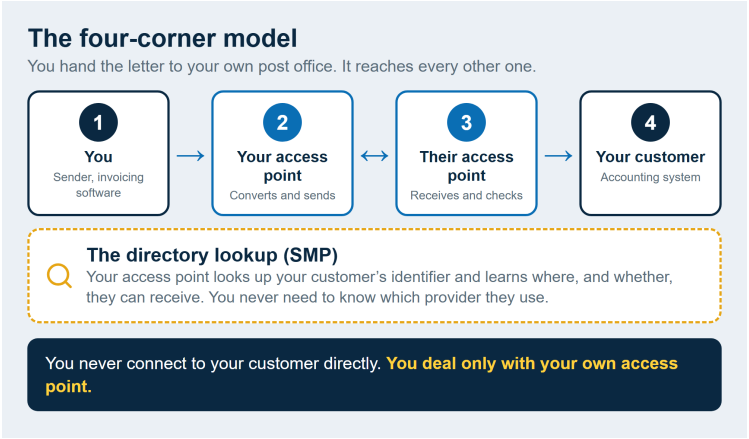
Peppol is an international network and set of technical specifications for exchanging electronic business documents, maintained by the non-profit association OpenPeppol. It was born in European public procurement and is now used by businesses and governments in many countries, in Europe and beyond. It carries invoices, credit notes and other documents.[10]

Two points matter for a small business:

1. **Peppol is a network and a rulebook, not a software product.** You do not buy "Peppol". You use a provider that is connected to it.
2. **Peppol is a channel, not a tax law.** Whether you must use it is decided by national rules. In Belgium, for example, the structured B2B mandate is built on it.[5] In other countries it is one option among several, or not used domestically at all.

The four-corner model

The heart of Peppol is the **four-corner model**.[10]



The four-corner model: you and your customer never connect directly

- **Corner 1: you, the sender,** create an invoice in your invoicing software.
- **Corner 2: your access point.** This is a certified service provider that is connected to the network. Your software hands the invoice to it, and it converts and validates it where needed.
- **Corner 3: your customer's access point.** Their provider, equally certified.
- **Corner 4: your customer,** whose accounting system receives the invoice.

You never connect to your customer directly, and you never need to know which provider they use. Your access point finds out by looking up your customer's **Peppol identifier** in a shared directory service. That lookup is handled by a component called an **SMP** (service metadata publisher), which records which documents each participant can receive and which access point to use. Most users never see the SMP; it is the postal sorting office.

An easy way to remember the idea: **you give a letter to your own post office, and it knows how to reach any other post office on the network.**

Identifiers: your address on the network

Every participant has a **Peppol identifier**, written as a scheme code and a value (for example a number issued by a national register).[10] Businesses typically use an existing, official identifier, such as a national enterprise number or a VAT number, so that the address is something their customers already know. Getting your identifier right and **registering it with your access point** is what makes you reachable. If a customer's identifier is missing, wrong or not registered to receive invoices, the sending fails with an error, not a surprise bounce.

Two jobs: sending and receiving

Small businesses often think only about sending. But **receiving** structured invoices is often the first obligation to arrive, and it is the one people forget. If your suppliers start sending you structured invoices through the network, you need an address that can receive them. In some countries the rules make receiving mandatory for VAT-registered businesses before, or at the same time as, sending. Chapters 6 and 7 show how.

What you need to do, and what you do not

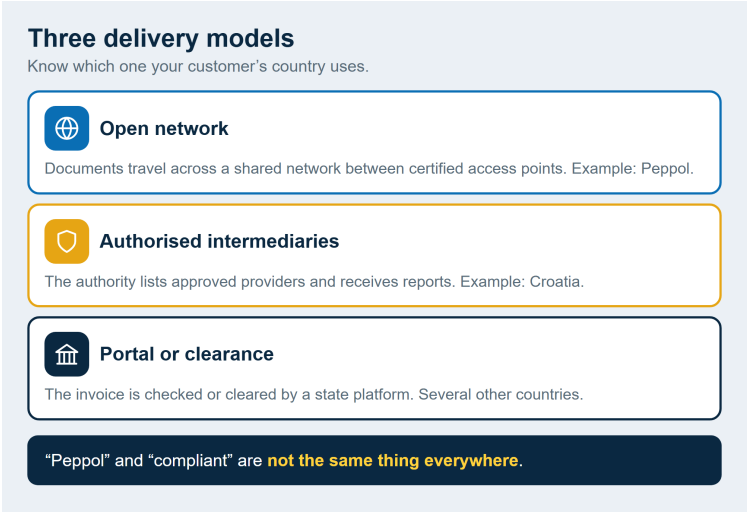
You need	You do not need
An invoicing tool, or provider, that is connected to the network	Your own access point or server
A correct, registered identifier	A technical team
Clean customer data and clear status handling	To understand XML
A policy for receiving invoices	To "install Peppol"

A public or private business can connect through an existing service provider rather than running its own access point.[10] The provider handles the technical exchange; your tool mainly needs to produce compliant invoices.

Peppol is not the only road

Some countries use a national platform, a government portal, authorised intermediaries or a clearance model in which the tax authority checks each invoice. Croatia's system is built around authorised information intermediaries and a national technical specification (Chapter 6). Poland,

Italy, France and others have their own models. Peppol is the most widely shared of them, which is why it is the best place to start, but it is not a universal answer.



Three delivery models: network, intermediary and portal

The rule: choose the route your customer's country requires, then check your software can take it. Do not assume "Peppol" and "compliant" mean the same thing everywhere.

Peppol in the real world: what it looks like to you

A non-technical way to picture a Peppol exchange from your desk:

1. You enter your customer's company and identifier in your invoicing tool.
2. The tool asks, in effect, "can this customer receive Peppol invoices?" and tells you yes or no.
3. You send. Within minutes the tool shows "delivered" or "rejected: reason".
4. Your customer's accounting software receives it with no retyping.

If the answer in step 2 is "no", you need to ask the customer to register, or use an alternative route the rules allow.

A worked example (fictional)

Lucas Verbeke runs a three-person accounting practice in Ghent. His clients include a joiner, a florist and a software company, all Belgian and VAT-liable. Lucas realises he is not choosing one tool; he is choosing a way to receive their suppliers' invoices *and* send theirs. He asks his clients' software provider two questions: "Are you a certified Peppol access point, or do you connect to one?" and "Can my clients receive and send?" The answer decides which clients he can keep on a single platform. Chapter 7 continues his story.

Take action this week

- ☐ Find out whether your invoicing provider is a Peppol access point or connects to one, and which countries' rules it supports.
- ☐ Ask for your Peppol identifier, and check it is the right official number for your business.
- ☐ Ask your biggest customers whether they are reachable on Peppol, and what identifier they use.
- ☐ Decide who in your business checks incoming structured invoices.

CHAPTER 4

Choosing Compatible Invoicing Software

A tidy desk with a notebook and closed laptop: good software choices start on paper

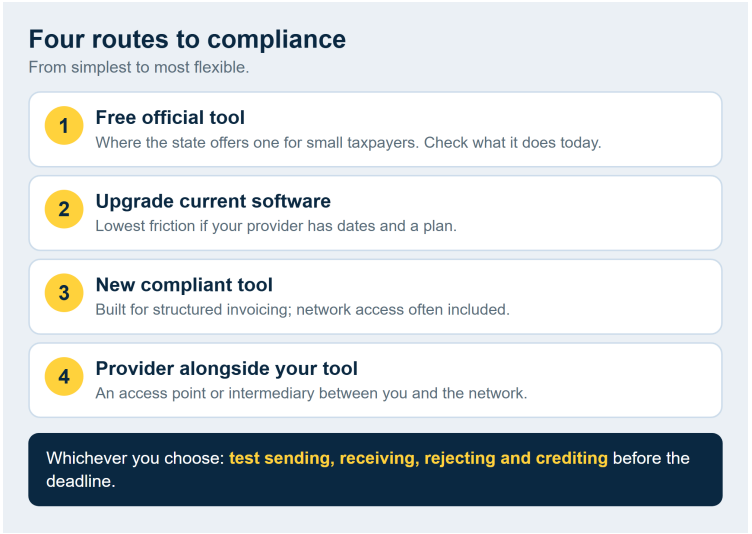
Most small businesses will meet e-invoicing through one decision: which software to use. This chapter helps you make that decision without becoming an expert.

Start with the question, not the product

Before comparing features, answer four questions. They narrow almost every choice.

1. **Where do my customers and suppliers sit?** Domestic Belgium, domestic Croatia, cross-border, or a mix.
2. **Do I send, receive or both?** Receiving is easier to forget and sometimes legally first.
3. **How many invoices do I handle?** Five a month and five hundred a month need different tools.
4. **Who does my books?** If your accountant uses a platform, compatibility with it can matter more than any feature.

The four routes small businesses take



Four ways a small business can become compliant, from simplest to most flexible

Route 1: a free or low-cost official tool. Some countries offer a state-run application for small taxpayers. Croatia's **MIKROeRAČUN**, offered by the Tax Administration, is described as a free application for receiving and handling e-invoices for businesses outside the VAT system.[2] Check what it covers today: sources describe the receive functions clearly and issue functions as planned or in testing.[3]

Route 2: your existing invoicing software, upgraded. Many established small-business invoicing and accounting products are adding compliant sending and receiving. This is usually the lowest-friction route, if your provider has published a credible plan and dates.

Route 3: a new compliant invoicing tool. A modern tool built for structured invoicing, often including network access as part of the subscription. Good if your current tool is unlikely to upgrade.

Route 4: a provider or intermediary alongside your tool. An access point or an authorised intermediary that sits between your system and the network, converting and sending. Useful for businesses with specialist software.

What to ask every provider

Copy these into an email. Appendix B has the full questionnaire.

- Which countries' e-invoicing rules do you support today, and which are planned with dates?
- Are you a certified Peppol access point, or an authorised intermediary in the relevant country? Under what authority?
- Do you support **both sending and receiving**?
- What exactly do you produce: pure structured data, a hybrid, or only a PDF with a data attachment?
- How do I see status, errors and rejections, and who sees them first?
- How do you handle credit notes, corrections and cancellations?
- What happens to my data if I leave? Can I export my invoices **in their original structured form**?
- What do I pay: per invoice, per month, per country?
- Where is my data stored, and who can access it?
- How will you tell me when rules change, and who is liable if your software gets it wrong?

Red flags

Green and red flags when choosing e-invoicing software

- **"We support e-invoicing"** with no country, standard or channel named.
- **PDF export described as e-invoicing.**
- **No answer on receiving.**
- **No way to export invoices in their original structured format.**
- **Pressure to sign multi-year terms** before the rules for your country are settled.
- **No named contact for compliance questions.**

Costs, honestly

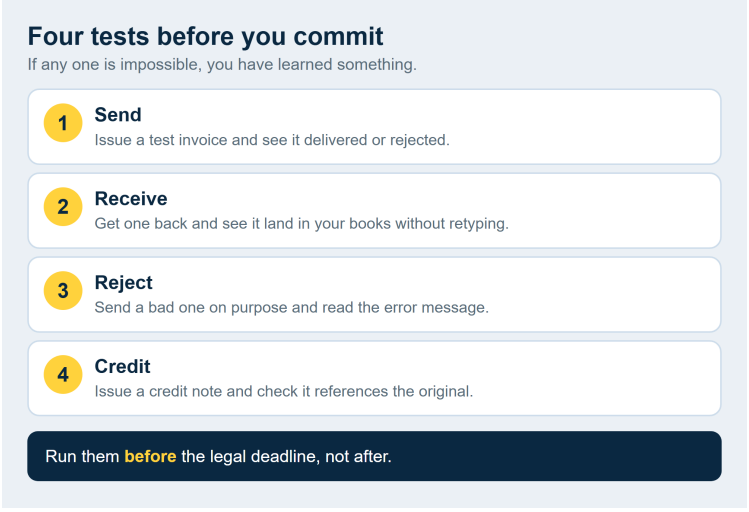
Costs are mostly small relative to the cost of getting it wrong, but they are real. Typical elements include a subscription, a per-invoice fee, a one-time setup, and training time. Avoid comparing only the headline price: add the hours your team will spend fixing rejected invoices, which is where cheap and poorly set-up tools hurt.

Use your accountant, carefully

Accountants are the single biggest influence on small-business software choices. If you are one, resist choosing a platform for all clients before you have checked that it supports each client's country and use. If you are a client, ask your accountant which platform they can connect to without double entry.

Testing before you commit

Insist on a **test run** before the legal deadline: send a test structured invoice to a friendly customer or the provider's test environment, receive one back, reject one on purpose, and issue a credit note. If any of these four steps is impossible, you have learned something important.



Four test invoices to run before you commit

A worked example (fictional)

Ivana and Marko run a small joinery in Rijeka. They use a cheap invoicing app that exports PDFs. Their accountant says they must be able to receive structured invoices from suppliers. They ask their app's provider the ten questions above and receive a vague reply with no dates. They then compare two alternatives with a test run. The second provider lets them send, receive, reject and credit within an hour. They choose it, with a month-by-month contract and a data-export clause, and tell their customers the new route.

The rule: choose software for the countries you trade with, test it before the deadline, and never buy a tool you cannot export from.

Take action this week

- ☐ Send the ten provider questions to your current software provider.
- ☐ Shortlist two alternatives and book a test.
- ☐ Ask your accountant which platform they can connect to.
- ☐ Add a clause on data export and monthly termination to any new contract.

CHAPTER 5

Digital Invoice Archiving

An archive room with unlabelled boxes: a digital archive needs labels too

An invoice you cannot find is almost as bad as an invoice you never kept. Archiving is the unglamorous half of e-invoicing, and the half most small businesses get wrong because nothing seems to break until an inspection or a dispute.

What the law asks for, in principle

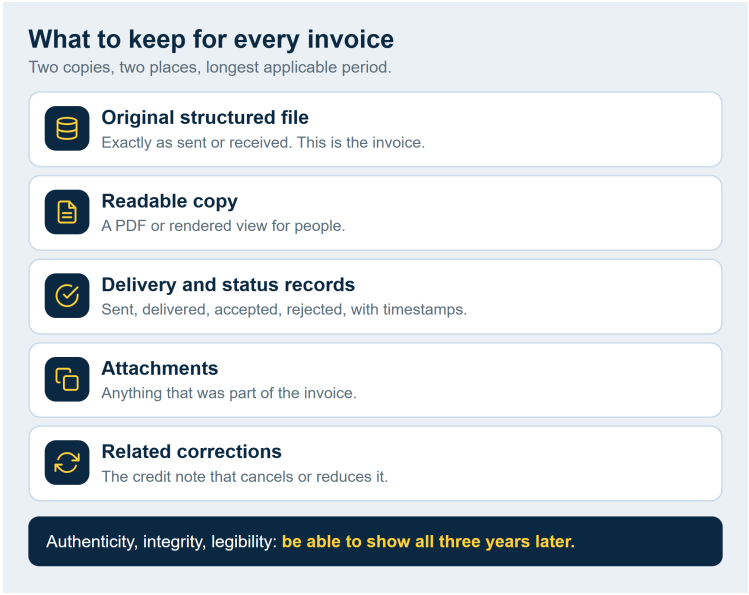
EU VAT rules require that the **authenticity of the origin, the integrity of the content and the legibility** of an invoice are guaranteed from issue until the end of the storage period, and they let businesses decide how, for instance by business controls that create a reliable link between an invoice and a supply.[12] Member states set their own storage periods and conditions for electronic storage.[12]

In plain terms, you should be able to show, years later, that:

- the invoice **is the one that was sent or received** (origin);
- it **has not been changed** (integrity);
- you **can read and process it** (legibility);
- you **can find it quickly** and in the form the authority expects.

The structured-data twist

For a structured invoice, the invoice **is the data file**. Keeping only a PDF rendering, or a printout, may not be enough in countries that treat the structured file as the original. Many providers advise storing the original structured file in addition to any human-readable copy, and some national rules require it.[12] Treat this as the default and confirm with your accountant.



What to keep: the original data, the readable copy and the proof of delivery

A good small-business archive for each invoice contains:

1. **The original structured file** exactly as sent or received.
2. **A readable copy** for people (a PDF or a rendered view).
3. **Delivery and status records**: sent, delivered, accepted or rejected, with timestamps.
4. **Any attachments** that formed part of the invoice.
5. **Any related correction**, such as the credit note.

How long?

Retention periods differ by country and by type of document, and the sources the author found **disagree**: for Belgium, figures of seven and ten years appear; for Croatia, figures from six to eleven years appear.[12] They are not repeated here as fact. **Ask your accountant for the period**

that applies to you, write it down in your register, and keep the longer of two candidate periods until you have an answer. Tax, company-law and accounting-law periods can differ; the longest usually governs your archive.

Where to keep it

Option	Good for	Watch for
The provider's own archive	Convenience, linked status	Lock-in; what happens if you leave; their retention limits
Your accounting software	Ties invoice to the ledger	Whether the original structured file is stored, not only a PDF
A separate archive or storage you control	Independence, portability	Discipline; integrity proof; access control
A certified archiving service	Evidence value in some markets	Cost; whether it is required or optional for you

A sound compromise for most small businesses is **two copies in two places**: the system that issued or received the invoice, and a separate encrypted backup you control, with a read-only copy for the accountant.

Integrity without jargon

You do not need exotic technology to show an invoice has not changed. Practical measures include:

- **Write-once or read-only storage** for the archive folder.
- **A file naming convention** that includes date, supplier and invoice number.
- **A log of who accessed or changed** archive contents.
- **Regular checks** that a sample of archived invoices still opens and matches its records.
- **Backups** stored separately, tested annually.

Personal data in your archive

Invoices contain names, addresses and sometimes bank details, which are personal data in the GDPR sense when they relate to individuals such as sole traders. Keep access limited to people who need it, use

encryption for backups, and delete when the retention period ends. The same register that tracks retention should track deletion. GDPRGard.eu has free tools for the data-protection side.

What goes wrong

Five archiving mistakes and how to avoid them

- Keeping only the PDF when the data file is the legal original.
- Relying on the provider's archive and losing access when the subscription ends.
- A messy folder structure nobody but one person understands.
- No record of rejections and corrections.
- Keeping everything forever, including after the period ends.

A worked example (fictional)

Nina, a freelance translator in Zagreb, receives a customer's structured invoice for her work from a supplier. Her software shows it as a neat PDF. Her accountant asks for the original file. She finds the provider only keeps a rendered copy for 12 months. She now exports monthly, stores the original and the PDF in a dated folder, and records the retention period in a one-page register (Appendix E).

The rule: keep the original data, a readable copy and the proof of delivery, in two places, for the longest period that could apply to you.

Take action this week

- ☐ Find out whether your tool stores the original structured file or only a PDF.
- ☐ Ask your accountant for the retention period that applies to you.
- ☐ Set up a second, read-only backup and test restoring one invoice.
- ☐ Start the archive register in Appendix E.

CHAPTER 6

Croatia's Fiscalisation 2.0

An old-town street at blue hour: a familiar city, a new invoicing system

Croatia has changed its invoicing system more than most. If you are a Croatian business, a freelancer working for Croatian clients, or a foreign supplier invoicing a Croatian company, this chapter matters. **Read it with the warning in the Educational Disclaimer in mind: the details below come from secondary sources and pointers to the official texts, and the sources do not agree on every point.**

What Fiscalisation 2.0 is

Croatia has long fiscalised cash and card receipts: every consumer sale is reported to the Tax Administration. The new system, known in public materials as **Fiskalizacija 2.0** and **eRačun**, widens this. It rests on the Fiscalisation Act published in the Official Gazette (NN 89/2025) and on binding technical specifications published by the Tax Administration.[1] [2] It combines three things:

1. **Structured e-invoices for domestic B2B and B2G transactions.**
2. **Fiscalisation or reporting of those invoices**, and of related events such as receipt, rejection and payment, to the Tax Administration.
3. **Fiscalisation of consumer (B2C) transactions** under the updated rules.

This book focuses on the first two, because they matter most to small businesses invoicing other businesses.

Who must do what, and when

Croatia's phases: VAT-registered businesses first, then those outside the VAT register

According to the sources the author could access:

- **VAT-registered businesses** are subject to the domestic B2B e-invoicing requirements from **1 January 2026**: issuing, receiving and reporting structured e-invoices.[1][3]
- **Businesses outside the VAT register** are on a phased path. Several sources say they are expected to be able to **receive** e-invoices from 2026, with the obligation to **issue** e-invoices and report extending to them from **1 January 2027**.[2][3]

Warning on scope. Sources describing the non-VAT businesses' 2026 position differ in wording, and a government page the author saw presents receiving and fiscalising receipt as starting 1 January 2026 and issuing as starting 1 January 2027, while other summaries describe different splits by taxpayer type.[2][3] If you are outside the VAT register, ask the Tax Administration or your accountant what applies to **your** legal form and activity, in writing.

Information intermediaries

A distinctive feature of the Croatian model is the **information intermediary** (*informacijski posrednik*). Under the Act, an intermediary is a legal or natural person that provides e-reporting and metadata services to taxpayers; the Tax Administration publishes the list of those who meet the required conditions, and an intermediary needs a conformity confirmation issued after testing.[2] In practice, a taxpayer chooses an intermediary and confirms the choice in the Tax Administration's system so that incoming e-invoices can reach them.[3]

Two practical consequences:

- **You choose, and you must tell the authority.** Not choosing or not confirming an intermediary can block receipt.
- **Responsibility is split.** According to the Tax Administration, the intermediary is responsible for the correctness of the software service it offers, while the taxpayer remains responsible for correct issuing, receiving and fiscalising.[2]

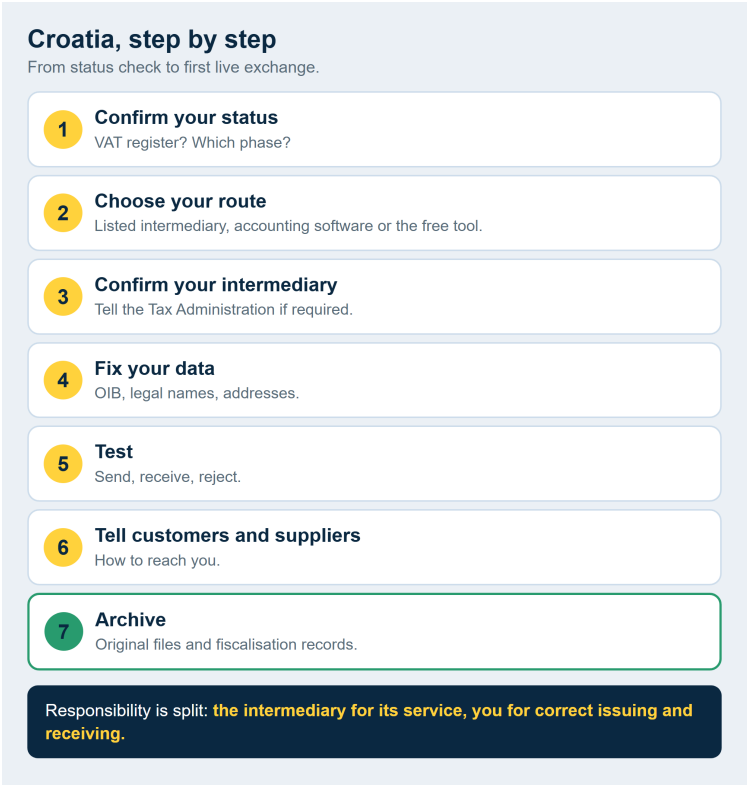
Format and exchange

The structured e-invoice in Croatia is based on the European standard. Sources describe UBL 2.1 and CII as supported syntaxes, with the Act and the Tax Administration's technical specification setting rules for exchange (reported as AS4 transport, endpoint discovery, certificates and conformity testing).[2][3] **Whether and how Peppol is used domestically in Croatia was described differently by different sources** (one describes Peppol as the network, another a national network with foreign suppliers sending over Peppol), and the author did not confirm this against the official specification.[3] Ask your intermediary which route applies to your domestic invoices and which to your foreign ones.

The free state tool: MIKROeRAČUN

For smaller businesses outside the VAT system, the Tax Administration offers **MIKROeRAČUN**, described as its own access point acting as an information intermediary, free of charge. Its documented functions include receiving e-invoices, fiscalising their receipt and rejecting them with fiscalisation of the rejection.[2] A secondary source reports that an upgraded version with issuing was planned for testing in autumn 2026; treat that as unconfirmed.[3] The practical lesson: **check what it does today before you rely on it for sending.**

What changes for a small Croatian business



Croatia, step by step: from status check to first live exchange

1. **Confirm your status.** Are you in the VAT register? What is your phase?
2. **Choose how you will receive and send**: a provider that is a listed intermediary, your accounting software, or the free tool where it fits.
3. **Confirm your intermediary** with the authority if required.
4. **Fix your data**: OIB (the Croatian personal identification number used in business), legal names and addresses.
5. **Test** sending and receiving, including a rejection.
6. **Update customers and suppliers** on how to reach you.
7. **Archive** the original structured files and the fiscalisation records (Chapter 5).

Foreign suppliers and Croatian customers

If you are a business outside Croatia selling to a Croatian VAT-registered customer, your customer may ask you to send structured invoices. Sources suggest foreign suppliers can send through Peppol, but the Croatian side's technical receipt rules and any registration requirements should be confirmed with the customer and their intermediary.[3] This is exactly the kind of "scope" question the book keeps flagging: a Croatian rule does not automatically bind you if you are not established there, but it may bind your customer, and they will ask.

Penalties and enforcement

The author did **not** find reliable penalty figures for Croatia in the sources consulted. The Fiscalisation Act is where the sanctions sit; ask your accountant for the current amounts and for how the authority is treating the first months of operation.

A worked example (fictional)

Mira (from the Introduction) returns. Her VAT-registered Croatian client now requires structured invoices. Mira, who is also VAT-registered, picks a provider that is a listed intermediary, confirms it with the Tax Administration, corrects her customers' OIB numbers, sends two test invoices and gets one rejected for a missing field. She fixes the template. Her second client, a sole trader outside the VAT register, can only receive for now; she keeps sending a PDF until the issuing obligation reaches **her** in 2027, and then re-checks the rule.

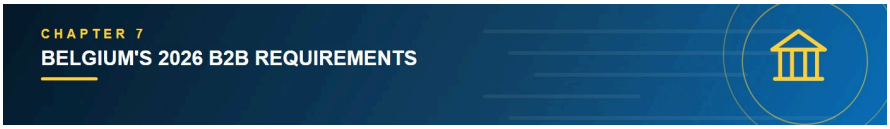
The rule: in Croatia, know your phase, choose a listed intermediary, tell the authority, and test before you rely on it.

Take action this week

- ☐ Confirm with your accountant whether you are in the VAT register and which Croatian phase applies to you.
- ☐ Ask providers whether they are on the Tax Administration's intermediary list.
- ☐ Confirm your chosen intermediary in the authority's system, if required.
- ☐ Check every customer's OIB in your records.

CHAPTER 7

Belgium's 2026 B2B Requirements



Canal-side houses at dusk: a country that chose one shared network for its invoices

Belgium is the clearest example in Europe of a country that put one network, Peppol, at the centre of a domestic B2B mandate. For a small business with Belgian customers or suppliers, it is also a reminder that a mandate can arrive on 1 January and still leave people unprepared on 2 January.

The rule in one paragraph

From **1 January 2026**, structured electronic invoices became mandatory for covered domestic B2B transactions between VAT-liable businesses established in Belgium.[4][5] The legal basis described in the sources is a law of 6 February 2024 that added a provision to the VAT Code and a Royal Decree of 14 July 2025 that confirmed the use of the Peppol BIS standard.[5] **A PDF alone is insufficient** for covered transactions, whether sent by email or uploaded to a portal.

Scope: who and what

Belgium: who the 2026 mandate covers, and what it does not

According to the sources:

- **Covered:** domestic B2B transactions between VAT-liable businesses established in Belgium.[5]
- **Not covered by this mandate (generally):** B2C sales, and cross-border transactions, although separate reporting or invoicing duties may apply. Cross-border e-invoicing is the subject of the EU-level reform in Chapter 8.
- **Exceptions:** the rules contain exemptions and special cases. The author did not verify the list, so **ask your accountant whether any apply to you**; do not assume you are exempt because you are small.

Format and channel

Invoices must follow the European standard and travel over the **Peppol network** as structured data; the sources describe the Peppol-based profile in the EN 16931 family with UBL or CII syntax as the default for businesses without other specific arrangements.[5] This means:

- You need a **Peppol-connected** way to send.
- You need a **Peppol identifier**, and so do your customers.
- You need a way to **receive**: Belgian businesses are expected to be reachable by their suppliers.

Chapter 3 explained each of these in plain words.

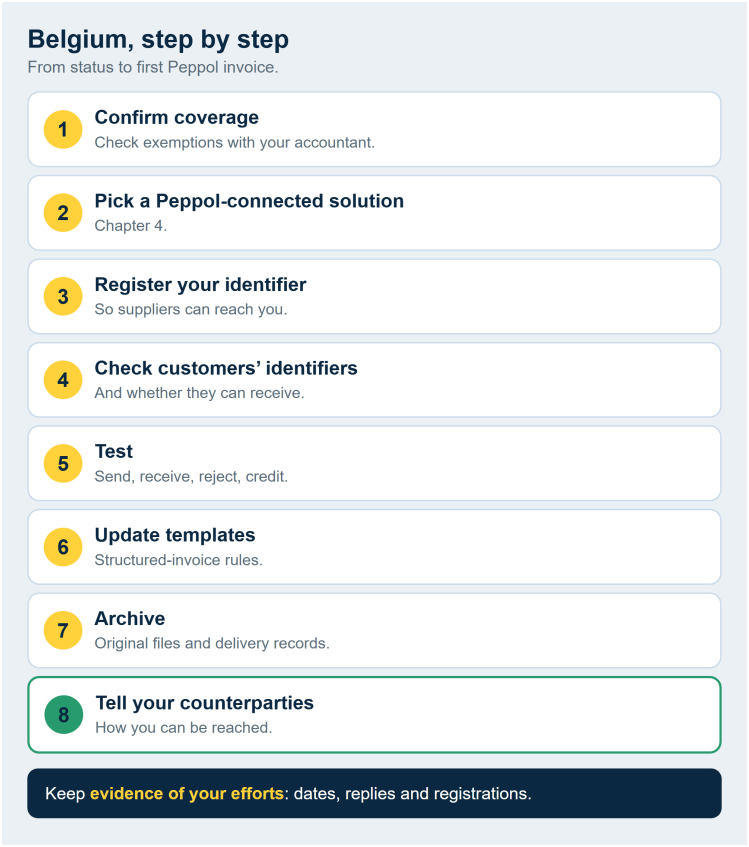
Tolerance and penalties

Belgium announced a **period of tolerance**: the Federal Public Service Finance stated on 2 December 2025 that it would not impose penalties from January to the end of March 2026, **provided** businesses could show timely and reasonable efforts to comply.[4] The obligation itself did not pause, and sources indicate the tolerance period ended on 31 March 2026 without extension.[4][6] A narrower relief for self-billed invoices, where a software provider was still implementing functionality, was reported to run to 30 June 2026.[6]

Penalties are reported in secondary sources as escalating fixed amounts of **EUR 1,500, EUR 3,000 and EUR 5,000** for repeated breaches, assessed case by case by the authority.[6] The author did not find the legal text for these figures and presents them as reported, not confirmed.

Because today is after the tolerance period, **the practical assumption is that the penalty regime applies.** Ask your accountant how the authority is handling first-time and small cases.

What changes for a small Belgian business



Belgium, step by step: from status to first Peppol invoice

1. **Confirm that your transactions are covered**, and that you and your customers are VAT-liable and established in Belgium.
2. **Pick a Peppol-connected solution** (Chapter 4).
3. **Register your identifier** so that suppliers can reach you.
4. **Check your customers' identifiers** and whether they are registered to receive.
5. **Test**: send, receive, reject, credit.
6. **Change your templates and numbering** to meet structured-invoice rules.
7. **Archive** original files and delivery records (Chapter 5).
8. **Tell your suppliers and customers** how you can be reached.

Common problems in the first year

- **Customers who are not registered to receive.** You cannot send an invoice to someone who cannot receive. Ask early.
- **Missing or inconsistent identifiers** in your customer records (Chapter 2).
- **Credit notes and discounts** that behave differently from the PDF habit.
- **Mixed customer bases** where some customers are covered and some are not; your software must switch routes per customer.
- **Self-billing and platforms**, where the invoice is created by someone other than the supplier; check specifically.
- **The reporting layer to come.** Sources describe a planned near-real-time **e-reporting** layer from **1 January 2028** using a five-corner variant of the model, but they conflict on whether the law has been enacted; **treat it as a draft until you see the official text.**[7]

Foreign businesses with Belgian customers

A business established outside Belgium is not automatically in the Belgian domestic mandate. But a Belgian customer may prefer or require structured invoices over Peppol, and Belgian VAT rules may apply to your supplies. Check with your adviser whether the mandate applies to you directly, and what your customer will accept.

A worked example (fictional)

Lucas Verbeke (from Chapter 3), the Ghent accountant, moves three client companies to a Peppol-connected accounting platform in December. One client's biggest customer is not yet registered to receive. The client keeps a documented record of the attempts, the dates and the customer's replies, and uses the route the rules allow while the customer registers. When the tolerance period ends in March, the file shows reasonable, timely effort and a completed registration. The point is not luck: **evidence of effort is part of compliance.**

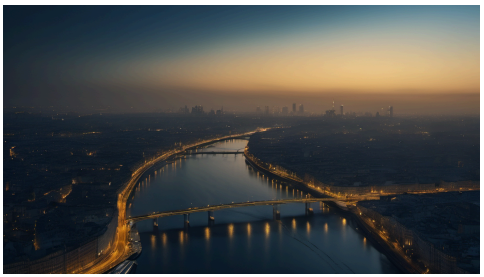
The rule: in Belgium, structured Peppol invoices are the invoice. Be reachable, check your customers' identifiers and keep evidence of your efforts.

Take action this week

- ☐ Confirm with your accountant whether your Belgian transactions are covered, and check for exemptions.
- ☐ Register your Peppol identifier and test receiving.
- ☐ Ask Belgian customers whether they are registered to receive, and record the answer.
- ☐ Put a note in your calendar to check the status of the 2028 reporting plan.

CHAPTER 8

Preparing for the EU VAT in the Digital Age Programme

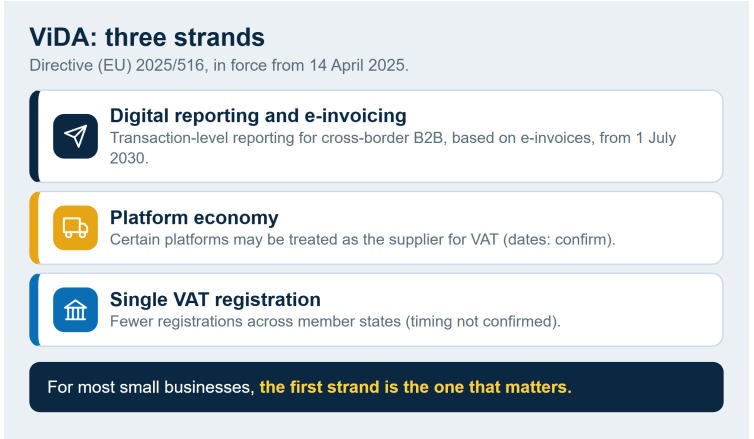


A European horizon at dusk: the next decade of VAT is digital

Croatia and Belgium are national stories. The **VAT in the Digital Age** package, usually shortened to **ViDA**, is the EU-level one, and it is why even a small business with no Belgian or Croatian customers should expect e-invoicing to reach it eventually.

What ViDA is

ViDA is a package of EU measures adopted on 11 March 2025 and published in the Official Journal on 25 March 2025: Directive (EU) 2025/516, Regulation (EU) 2025/517 and Implementing Regulation (EU) 2025/518, in force from 14 April 2025.[8] It has three main strands:



The three strands of ViDA: reporting and e-invoicing, platforms and one VAT registration

1. **Digital reporting requirements and e-invoicing** for transactions between businesses.
2. **The platform economy**, where certain platforms (for example in short-term accommodation and passenger transport) may be treated as the supplier for VAT.
3. **A single VAT registration** approach to reduce the need to register in multiple member states.

For most small businesses the first strand matters most.

The 2030 milestone

The market signal this book relies on is that **cross-border B2B digital reporting based on e-invoicing applies from 1 July 2030.**[8][9] Secondary sources describe what it means in practice:

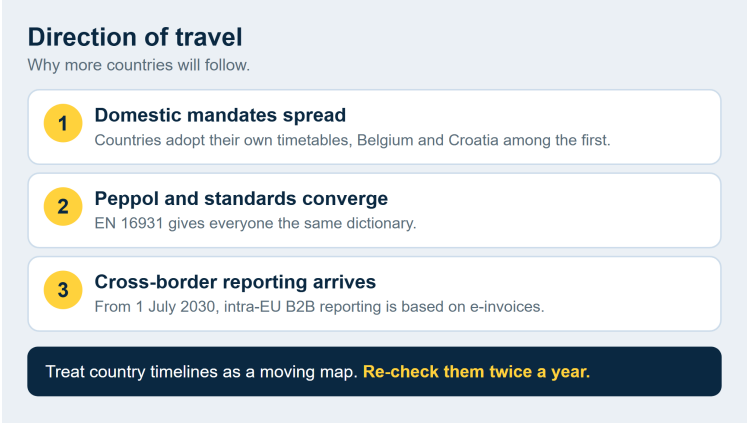
- **Intra-EU B2B transactions** will be reported to tax authorities **per transaction** and in near real time, replacing the periodic EC Sales List. [9]
- **E-invoices following the European standard** become the default invoice for these transactions, with a short deadline for issuing them (sources give ten days).[9]
- **Information flows to a central system** at EU level, where the tax authorities can see it.[9]

The author did not read the Directive text for these article-level details, so the exact scope, definitions, exemptions and deadlines should be confirmed on EUR-Lex or with your adviser. The platform-economy

dates are reported as optional from 1 July 2028 and mandatory from 1 January 2030; the single-registration timing was **not confirmed** in the sources found.[9]

What ViDA also does: domestic mandates

Beyond the cross-border rules, ViDA is generally described as letting member states adopt domestic e-invoicing mandates without the individual permission procedure that was needed before.[8] That is one reason mandates are spreading: Belgium and Croatia are early examples, and others are on their own schedules. **Treat country timelines as a moving map, and re-check them twice a year.**



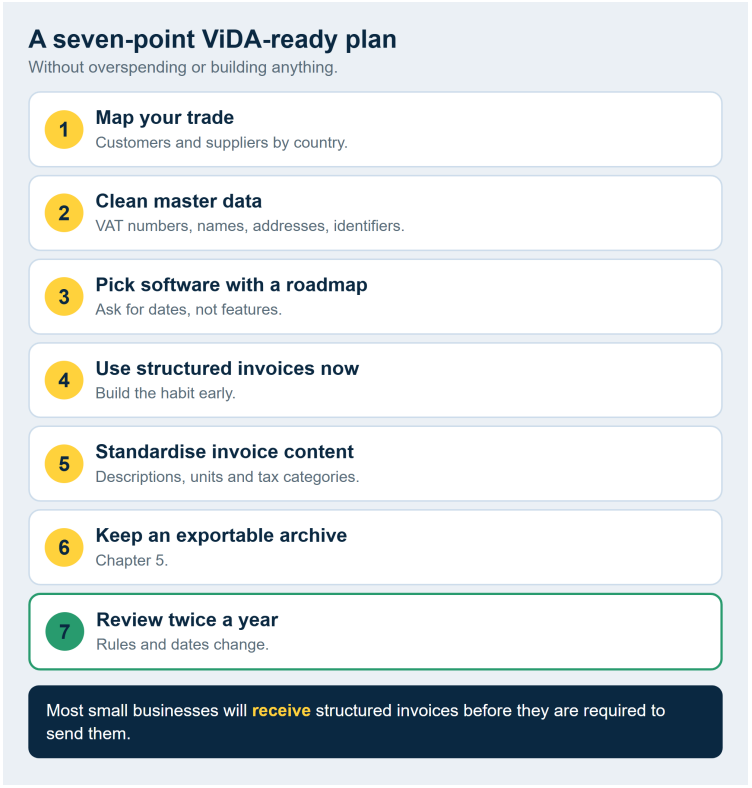
Why more countries will follow: the EU-level direction of travel

Other countries: a short outline

Several other countries have mandates or timelines that may touch you. The author did not verify their current dates in this research, so each is a **pointer to check**, not a statement of fact:

Country	What to check
Germany	Receiving structured B2B invoices; phased obligations to issue
France	Phased B2B e-invoicing and e-reporting through accredited platforms
Poland	National platform and its phased obligation
Italy	Long-standing national clearance model
Spain	Planned B2B mandate and national platform

How to prepare: a seven-point plan



A seven-point plan to be ViDA-ready without overspending

1. **Map your trade.** Where are your B2B customers and suppliers, domestic and EU?
2. **Clean your master data.** VAT numbers (validated against the EU's VIES service), legal names, addresses, identifiers.
3. **Pick software with a roadmap**, not a fixed feature list: ask for dates for new countries and for cross-border reporting.
4. **Use structured invoices now** where you can, even before you must, to build habit.
5. **Standardise your invoice content**: item descriptions, units and tax categories that map cleanly.
6. **Keep your archive tidy** and exportable (Chapter 5).
7. **Review twice a year.** Rules and dates change; set a calendar reminder.

What you should not do

- **Do not wait until 2030.** The first obligations are already here in some countries, and the habits take time.
- **Do not build a custom solution.** Small businesses almost never need to.
- **Do not trust a single summary**, including this book, for dates. Verify against official texts.
- **Do not forget receiving.** Most small businesses will be receiving structured invoices before they are required to send them.

A worked example (fictional)

Petra runs a small online training business in Slovenia selling to companies in five EU countries. She does not know which rules apply. She builds a one-page table of customers by country (Appendix C), finds that two countries already have mandates or phases that may reach her customers, picks a platform that publishes a country roadmap, and sets a twice-yearly review. She does not know the 2030 details, and does not need to yet. She knows what she needs to find out.

The rule: ViDA makes e-invoicing the direction of travel for the whole EU. Prepare by cleaning data, choosing a platform with a roadmap and checking dates twice a year.

Take action this week

- ☐ Fill in the country-scope checker in Appendix C.
- ☐ Ask your provider for their ViDA and country roadmap.
- ☐ Validate your customers' EU VAT numbers.
- ☐ Set a recurring twice-yearly review.

Conclusion: From PDF to Practice

A calm small office in the morning: the work of e-invoicing is mostly quiet housekeeping

Mira still designs for a living. What changed is that her invoices are now data, her customers' identifiers are correct, her intermediary is confirmed, and a copy of every file sits in two places with a note of how long to keep it. The process took her three weeks, most of it in the first week, and a few hours since.

That is the whole shape of a calm transition. **Know where you trade. Know your status. Choose software for those countries. Test it. Fix your data. Be reachable. Archive the original. Check dates twice a year.**

None of this requires a large budget, and none of it is permanent. Laws will change, dates will move, providers will merge and standards will be revised. Your data, your register and your habits are what let you adapt without panic.

The PDF is not going away as a way to read an invoice. It is going away as a way to *be* one, in a growing list of countries. Start with the ten-minute check, fill in Appendix C this week, and move one customer to a structured invoice before you have to.

APPENDIX A

E-Invoicing Readiness Audit

Fill this in once, in one sitting, with your accountant if you can. It shows where you stand today.

#	Question	Your answer	Owner
1	In which countries am I VAT-registered?		
2	Which countries are my main customers and suppliers in?		
3	What does my invoicing tool produce today (PDF, hybrid, structured)?		
4	Can it send through a network or authorised intermediary? Which?		
5	Can it receive structured invoices?		
6	Do I have a Peppol identifier? Which one?		
7	Have I confirmed an intermediary where the country requires it?		
8	Are all customer identifiers and legal names correct?		
9	Where are original invoice files stored? Is there a second copy?		
10	Who owns e-invoicing in my business or at my accountant?		

Score yourself. Five or more blanks means you should complete Appendix C and Appendix F this month.

APPENDIX B

Software-Selection Questionnaire

Send this to each provider you are considering. Keep the replies together with the date.

#	Question	Their answer	Red flag if
1	Which countries' e-invoicing rules do you support today? Which are planned, and when?		No dates or no list
2	Are you a certified Peppol access point, or do you connect to one? Which?		Cannot name it
3	In countries that require authorised intermediaries, are you listed? Where?		"Soon"
4	Do you support both sending and receiving?		Sending only
5	What exactly do you produce: pure structured data, hybrid or PDF?		PDF called "e-invoice"
6	How do I see delivery status and rejections?		Email only
7	How are credit notes and corrections handled?		Editing sent invoices
8	Can I export invoices in their original structured form?		No
9	What are the full costs, per invoice, per month, per country?		Unclear
10	Where is data stored and who can access it?		No answer
11	Notice period and data-return terms if I leave?		Multi-year lock-in
12	Who is my compliance contact, and what is your responsibility if the rules change?		No named contact

APPENDIX C

Country-Scope Checker

List your customers and suppliers by country and fill in what applies. **The "Rule in force" column must come from your accountant or an official source, not from this book.**

#	Counterparty	Country	VAT-registered?	Domestic or cross-border?	Rule in force (and date)	Route to use	Test done
1							
2							
3							
4							
5							
6							
7							
8							

Reading it: a row with "domestic, mandate in force" needs a structured invoice through the named route now. A row with "cross-border" is outside most current domestic mandates but may be affected by ViDA from 2030 and by your customer's own policy.

APPENDIX D

Letter to Customers and Suppliers

Copy, adapt and send. Plain words work better than technical ones.

For customers

> Subject: How to receive our invoices from [date]
>
> Dear [name],
>
> Following the introduction of structured e-invoicing in [country], we are changing how we send invoices. From [date] we will send them as structured electronic invoices through [Peppol / our provider / the national route].
>
> To make sure you receive them, please tell us: (1) your legal name and tax or enterprise number, (2) your Peppol identifier or intermediary, if you have one, and (3) the contact for invoice questions.
>
> If you cannot yet receive structured invoices, please let us know by [date] so we can agree an interim arrangement.
>
> Kind regards, [Name, business, VAT number]

For suppliers

> Subject: Sending us your invoices
>
> Dear [name],
>
> From [date], please send invoices to us as structured e-invoices to [identifier or address]. PDF invoices may no longer be accepted for domestic transactions in [country]. Please confirm you can do this, or tell us what help you need.
>
> Kind regards, [Name, business]

APPENDIX E

Invoice Archive Register

One row per type of record. Review once a year.

#	Record type	Original format	Where stored (copy 1)	Where stored (copy 2)	Retention period	Source of that period	Deletion date / owner
1	Sales invoices						
2	Purchase invoices						
3	Credit notes						
4	Delivery and status records						
5	Rejections and corrections						
6	Intermediary / provider confirmations						
7	Correspondence on mandates (tolerance, queries)						

Integrity checklist

- ☐ Archive folder is read-only or write-once.
- ☐ File names include date, counterparty and invoice number.
- ☐ A second copy exists and a test restore has worked.
- ☐ Access is limited and logged.
- ☐ Retention period is written down with its source.

APPENDIX F

90-Day Action Plan

Days	Action	Owner	Done
1-7	Complete Appendix A and the country-scope checker (Appendix C)		
1-7	Check every customer's identifier and legal name		
8-21	Send Appendix B to two or three providers and compare		
8-21	Ask your accountant to confirm scope and deadlines in writing		
22-35	Choose a route and sign a short, exportable contract		
22-35	Register identifier and confirm intermediary if required		
36-50	Run the four tests: send, receive, reject, credit		
36-50	Send Appendix D letters to customers and suppliers		
51-70	Move first live customer to a structured invoice		
51-70	Start the archive register (Appendix E)		
71-90	Review rejections and fix data causes		
71-90	Set a twice-yearly rules review in the calendar		

Glossary

Access point. A certified service provider connected to the Peppol network that sends and receives documents for its customers.

AS4. A secure message-exchange protocol used for sending business documents over the Peppol network and in some national systems.

B2B, B2G, B2C. Business to business, business to government, business to consumer.

CII. Cross Industry Invoice, one of two XML syntaxes for the European invoice standard.

CIUS. Core Invoice Usage Specification: a country or community's narrowed version of the European standard.

Credit note. A document that cancels or reduces a previous invoice, used instead of editing a sent invoice.

DRR. Digital reporting requirements: the EU's rules on reporting transactions digitally to tax authorities.

EN 16931. The European standard for the semantic data model of the core electronic invoice.

E-invoice (structured). An invoice issued, sent and received in a structured electronic format that a computer can process automatically.

Fiskalizacija 2.0. Croatia's extended fiscalisation system covering e-invoices and reporting.

Information intermediary. In Croatia, an authorised service provider for e-reporting and metadata exchange for taxpayers.

OIB. The Croatian personal identification number used for individuals and businesses.

Peppol. A network and set of specifications for exchanging electronic business documents.

Peppol BIS Billing 3.0. The Peppol invoicing profile based on the European standard.

SMP. Service Metadata Publisher: the directory component of Peppol that records which documents a participant can receive and where.

UBL. Universal Business Language, one of two XML syntaxes for the European invoice standard.

ViDA. VAT in the Digital Age: the EU package of VAT reforms covering digital reporting, platforms and registration.

VIES. The EU's VAT Information Exchange System, used to validate VAT numbers.

A Note on GDPRGard.eu

Invoices carry personal data about sole traders and employees, and archives and providers add data-protection questions of their own. GDPRGard.eu offers free tools, guides and articles for small businesses on GDPR, including help with processor agreements, retention schedules and vendor checks that apply directly to the choices in this book.

About the Author

Zirlandia Milkovic writes practical, plain-English guides on data protection, cyber-security, digital compliance and building a business with confidence. She believes technology and regulation should give small businesses and the people in them more control, not less, and that nobody should need a law degree or a technical background to understand their obligations or to protect their customers and colleagues.

She is the author of a series of business guides, including *GDPR Made Simple for Women Founders*, and her work focuses on turning complex rules and fast-moving change into simple steps, checklists and templates that busy people can use on Monday morning. She is also behind **GDPRGard**, a growing collection of free GDPR tools, guides and articles for small businesses, available at gdprgard.eu.

From PDF to Peppol grew out of a simple observation: the invoice, the oldest document in business, is turning into data, country by country, and small businesses are being told about it by their customers instead of their governments. If this guide helped you, an honest review where you bought it helps other readers find it.

Visit **gdprgard.eu** for free tools, articles and updates.

Notes and Sources

1. Croatia, Fiscalisation Act (Zakon o fiskalizaciji), Narodne novine 89/2025 (13 June 2025). Seen as a search result link only; the text was not read.
2. Croatian Tax Administration (Porezna uprava) pages: "Vodič kroz Fiskalizaciju 2.0", the MIKROeRAČUN page, and the notice on confirming an information intermediary for receiving e-invoices. Seen through search summaries; pages not read in full. Describes receiving and fiscalising receipt from 1 January 2026 and issuing from 1 January 2027 for the group it addresses, the definition of information intermediaries, the conformity confirmation and the split of responsibility.
3. Secondary guides on Croatian e-invoicing (Sovos, Avalara, EDICOM, B2Brouter, VATit, Invopop, lookuptax and others), seen through search summaries. They agree on 1 January 2026 for VAT-registered businesses and 1 January 2027 for issuing by non-VAT businesses, but differ on the non-VAT receiving date, on whether Peppol is used domestically, and on retention periods. A 2 September 2026 announcement about an upgraded MIKROeRAČUN was cited by one secondary source only.
4. Belgian Federal Public Service Finance, "E-invoicing: period of tolerance during the first three months of 2026" (announced 2 December 2025), and KPMG, Banqup and other commentary. Seen through search summaries.
5. Belgian law of 6 February 2024 (VAT Code, new Article 53 paragraph 2bis) and Royal Decree of 14 July 2025 on mandatory structured B2B e-invoicing from 1 January 2026, as described by Comarch, Vertex, fiskaly and Deloitte Belgium summaries. Legal texts not read.
6. Penalty tiers (EUR 1,500, 3,000 and 5,000), end of tolerance on 31 March 2026 and the self-billing relief to 30 June 2026, from InnovateTax, Comarch, Orbitax and similar secondary sources; legal text not found.
7. Belgian near-real-time e-reporting planned from 1 January 2028 (five-corner model): sources conflict on whether the draft law is enacted (Comarch and others). Treat as a draft.
8. Directive (EU) 2025/516, Regulation (EU) 2025/517 and Implementing Regulation (EU) 2025/518 (ViDA package), adopted 11 March 2025, published in the Official Journal 25 March 2025, in force 14 April 2025, as reported by vatit, Sovos and eurofiscalis summaries. Directive text not read. The point on domestic mandates without a derogation is working knowledge; verify.
9. ViDA digital reporting and e-invoicing from 1 July 2030, transaction-level reporting replacing EC Sales Lists, EN 16931 invoices within ten days, central VIES, platform-economy dates from 1 July 2028 (optional) and 1 January 2030 (mandatory) (Eurofiscalis, Sovos, econnect, Accountancy Europe factsheet; summaries). A single-VAT-registration date was not confirmed. Transposition deadline statements in sources conflicted.

10. Peppol four-corner model, access points, SMP and identifiers: German federal e-invoicing FAQ (e-rechnung-bund.de), econnect, Maltese Ministry of Finance Peppol guide and other explanatory pages (summaries). OpenPeppol specifications not read.
11. EN 16931 with UBL and CII syntaxes and the Peppol BIS Billing 3.0 profile: working knowledge; check the standards and OpenPeppol documentation.
12. Directive 2006/112/EC (VAT Directive), Articles 233 and 245 on authenticity, integrity, legibility and storage, and national retention periods as described by Basware, B2Brouter, VATit and others. The sources conflict (Belgium 7 or 10 years; Croatia 6 or 11 years) and are not relied on.
13. Directive 2006/112/EC, Articles 217 and 232, on the definition of electronic invoice and recipient acceptance: working knowledge.

Not verified by the author: the Croatian Fiscalisation Act and technical specification; whether Peppol is used for domestic Croatian invoices; the Belgian legal texts, exemptions and penalty provisions; the status of Belgium's 2028 e-reporting law; the ViDA article-level texts and any single-registration date; retention periods in any country; and the current rules in Germany, France, Poland, Italy and Spain. Provider and product names, where they appear, are illustrative. Mira, Lucas Verbeke, Ivana and Marko, Nina, Petra and all events in the worked examples are fictional.